

MICHEL FOUCAULT — L'ARCHÉOLOGIE DU SAVOIR

A study note for **Projet Complexe**: a semantic environment (tasks, knowledge, research, relations, agents) built **on top of ASC**, not inside it. Gallimard, 1969 (*tel* reprint of this scan, ISBN 2-07-026999-X). One book. No figures.

The revival question still holds:

How can a computational environment become sufficiently explicit, nameable and composable that both humans and autonomous agents can navigate and act within it?

Foucault’s use here is not a Foucault ontology, not a page-count digest, and not a theory of “the user’s mind.” It is a set of refusals and one unit. They matter because a second-brain-class app defaults to the **history of ideas**: notes as an œuvre, retrieval as commentary, the corpus as archive, the chat as a voice, the persona as a subject, the pile as knowledge.

ASC must not become that app. Projet Complexe may be that app **if** it does not restore those unities. Projet Complexe ASC stays thin (**research**, **index**, **extract**, **recognize**, **relate**, **build**, **run-agent**, **inspect-agent**, **stop-agent**, **publish**).

French terms kept. Each part ends with **For the app** — the same argument in this architecture’s vocabulary.

THE THREE SCOPES (DO NOT COLLAPSE THEM)

Scope	Asks	Must remain	Must not become
ASC	What is this thing, where is it, how is it addressed, what can be done with it?	Files, processes, machines, services, workers, capabilities, hooks, entry points, composition, execution.	A theory of énoncés; an archive; a second-brain ontology.
Projet Complexe	What am I trying to accomplish, what do I know, how are things related, how should I act?	Tasks, knowledge, research, relations, projects, agents.	An OS; a second ASC; a history of the user’s ideas.
Projet Complexe ASC	Which ASC possibilities does this environment expose, under which names?	The thin pivots above.	A discursive formation pretending to be infrastructure.

Foucault’s first move is to refuse a master term (œuvre, author, spirit of an age). The same refusal: do not rebuild one Work that contains files, meanings, and agents.

FOUR REFUSALS

- History of ideas as default ontology.** Tradition, influence, development, mentality, œuvre, book, author, origin, commentary. Filing categories that restore continuity.
- Linguistic unit as unit of knowledge.** Sentence, proposition, speech act, token, chunk, embedding. Necessary for processing. Insufficient for “what counts as having been said *here*.”
- Corpus as archive.** Folder, vector store, library, “memory.” Documentary masses. The archive is the *law* of what can appear among them as énoncés.
- Subject as author or persona.** Who speaks is a position (status, site, right to speak). A system prompt is a costume.

Plus a threshold discipline:

- Savoir ≠ science.** An index is not an epistemology. A research pivot is not a science of the environment.

I — INTRODUCTION (P. 7)

Historians of events move toward long series and deep socles (routes, grain, population). Historians of ideas move the other way: toward **ruptures** (Bachelard’s *seuils*, Canguilhem’s displacements of concepts, Serres’s recurrent redistributions of a science’s past, Althusser’s *coupure*).

The joint for this app: **the questioning of the document**. History’s first task is no longer to interpret what traces *voulaient dire*, but to work a **matérialité documentaire** from the inside — organise, cut, distribute, series, units, relations. Old history turned monuments into documents (memory: what does this vestige say). New history treats **documents as monuments**: a mass with a configuration, not a voice.

Total history (one spirit of an age) yields to **general history**: several series, relations between series, no centre. Discontinuity is a working concept, not a scandal.

This book is the theoretical redress of *Histoire de la folie*, *Naissance de la clinique*, *Les Mots et les choses* — not a method applied afterwards. Not structuralism. Not a founding subject. Discourse as **practices** obeying **rules**.

For the app

- Notes, PDFs, chats, tickets, commits are documentary material. **index**, **extract**, **relate** work them as monuments. **research** that only summarises “meaning” is old history.
- A vector store of chunks still treats traces as voices. Monument: where filed, which pivot produced it, which other énoncés it sits among — not only an embedding.
- Different clocks: filesystem and capabilities change slowly; chat turns fast. Do not periodise them as one “second brain timeline.”
- Re-index is a Serres redistribution of what appears, not “catching up with the user’s mind.”
- **extract** must leave a monument (structure, source pointer, figures as-is). A paraphrase that replaces the source is commentary.
- ASC works materiality (files, processes). What counts as a *statement* in the knowledge environment is Projet Complexe’s problem — as description, not as mind-reading.

II — LES RÉGULARITÉS DISCURSIVES (P. 29)

UNITIES TO SUSPEND (II.I, P. 31)

Tradition makes successive things look like the same practice lasting. **Influence** is a fluid between works (and between notes). **Développement** makes the present the truth of the past (the roadmap as destiny). **Mentalité** flattens dispersion into a spirit (“the age of agents”). **The book** is not a parallelepiped: it is a node in a network (references, extracts, exports, conversations). **The œuvre** is not given by a signature (user name, model name, `run-agent` id). **The author** is not the source of discourse. What remains: énoncés in their **dispersion**, and the rules of that dispersion. **For the app.** Do not file the environment as “everything I thought.” A `.md` file is not a natural knowledge unit. `relate` is not an influence graph. Agent memory that concatenates “everything this week” rebuilds the œuvre.

FORMATIONS (II.II, P. 44)

Four hypotheses of unity, all broken: same object, same style of énonciation, same concepts, same theme. What remains: a **formation discursive** is a **system of dispersion** whose **rules of formation** can be described at four concurrent levels — objects, enunciative modalities, concepts, strategies. Not a genesis (objects first). Not a worldview. Rules are in the practice, not in speakers’ heads. **For the app.** A tag, folder, or embedding neighbourhood is similarity, not a formation. Do not unify Projet Complexe by object (“knowledge”), style (“markdown”), concept (“task/knowledge/agent”), or theme (“second brain”). Describe rules: what counts as a task, who may run an agent, which traces become indexes. Do not put `formation discursive` in ASC as a type.

OBJECTS (II.III, P. 55)

The object is not the referent. It is formed by **surfaces d’émergence** (where it can appear to be named), **instances de délimitation** (who may name it), **grilles de spécification** (how it is divided and derived). Discourse constitutes its objects. Non-discursive practices (institutions, machines, disk) constrain without being the “real meaning.” **For the app.** `document`, `task`, `agent`, `capability` are formed objects, not natural kinds. Surfaces: filesystem, GUI, chat, process table. Authorities: ASC declarations, PC schemas, the user, permissions. Grids: file vs process; task vs knowledge vs research; worker vs agent. Conflicts of delimitation (IDE says agent, ASC has a worker) are data, not a bug to solve with a master type. `recognize` applies a grid on a surface under an authority — OCR recognizes text, not a monument.

MODALITIES (II.IV, P. 68)

Who speaks: **status** (entitlement, competence, legal/technical bundle), **institutional site** (hospital, library — here: machine, worktree, index), **positions** (questioning, listening, seeing, observing a population). The subject is a **determined empty place**, occupiable by different individuals or procedures. Discourse is not the expression of a subject; the subject is derived. **For the app.** “You are a helpful assistant” is a costume. A modality specifies capabilities, writable trees, site, and which positions this occupancy may hold. The same pivot `research` occupied by the user, a local worker, or a cloud subagent is not the same occupancy. `inspect-agent` / `stop-agent` exist so the place is not anonymous. Persona does not belong in ASC.

CONCEPTS (II.V, P. 75)

Not growing clarification. **Champ de présence:** énoncés admitted, disputed, or excluded *here* (operations: quote, refute, ignore). **Champ de concomitance:** other domains allowed as model or authority. **Champ de mémoire:** constructed past (Serres: the present redistributes it). Plus **procedures of intervention** (rewrite, formalise, transfer, delimit validity). **For the app.** `index` that only stores terms is a dictionary. Presence is admission, not “the file exists on disk.” Unbounded `research` is a flood of concomitance; revival already subordinates research to a task. Silent compaction forges memory; a summary is another énoncé that must point at what it rarefies. ASC must not admit “knowledge” / “meaning” as native concepts.

STRATEGIES (II.VI, P. 85)

A formation holds **points of diffraction:** exclusive options that do not split the positivity. Choice among them is strategic, not “deeper truth.” A discourse can function as science, critique, program, justification. **For the app.** Chatbot vs OS-collaborator vs research-worker can be diffracted strategies in one positivity (same objects, same inspect/stop) — or two formations if objects split (an unstoppable ghost vs a named worker). The three-scope split is a strategic exclusion of “ASC as second brain.” Defaults (always spawn a researcher) are strategies: name them. `publish` places an énoncé in another field; it is not a save button.

REMARKS (II.VII, P. 94)

The four levels are simultaneous. **Positivité:** a practice of énoncés exists and can be described — not that it is true. **Pratique discursive:** anonymous regularity until positions are named. **For the app.** Do not implement the four levels as a pipeline. A running Projet Complexe already has a positivity (or not) whether or not it is “correct.” Hooks that fire as “the system” restore a transcendental subject as infrastructure.

III — L'ÉNONCÉ ET L'ARCHIVE (P. 103)

The technical heart. One mapping:

Term	Is not	Is
<i>énoncé</i>	sentence, proposition, speech act, chunk, embedding	function of existence of signs in a field

Term	Is not	Is
archive	library, corpus, DB, folder, memory	law of what can appear as an énoncé
positivité	truth, schema	that a practice of énoncés exists
savoir	science, “the model’s knowledge,” the knowledge base	space a positivity makes knowable

DÉFINIR L'ÉNONCÉ (III.I, P. 105)

Same proposition can be two énoncés (tautology in a logic book vs example in a grammar). A table, a graph, a classification, a directory listing can be énoncés without being sentences. A grammatical sentence can fail to be an énoncé *here* (scratch, discarded CoT, hallucination never admitted). The énoncé is not a hidden structure. It is a **function of existence**. **Énonciation**: the unique event (this process, this ink). **Énoncé**: repeatable under a **regime of materiality** (copy, quotation, legal deposit, path). Same signs, different regime → possibly different énoncé. **For the app**. RAG returns signs. An énoncé exists only if one can say field, position, associated énoncés, material regime. Do not store `Énoncé` as an ASC type. Markdown vs PDF of the same note is a regime of repetition to declare, not automatic identity. One `run-agent` is an énonciation; the pivot’s declared behaviour is an énoncé.

FONCTION ÉNONCIATIVE (III.II, P. 116)

Four conditions, none sufficient alone:

1. **Référentiel** (not a referent) — a space of differentiations. “The server is down” needs the grille where machines, services, and “down” are distinguished (ASC vocabulary if computational; PC task vocabulary if work). Mixing referentials collapses scopes (“the knowledge base is down”).
2. **Subject-position** (not an author) — determined empty place. Occupied by user, worker, hook. `inspect-agent` reads occupancy; `stop-agent` empties it.
3. **Associated field** (not a context window) — other énoncés it repeats, opposes, applies, opens or closes. `relate` can constitute a field. Concatenation cannot.
4. **Instituted materiality** (not mere bytes) — `/tmp` vs `data/ideas/`, log rotation, print HTML for PDF export. An emission that exists only in a residual stream is not here.

Missing one: generation, not an énoncé. Do not make the four into required JSON fields. They are tests for description.

DESCRIPTION (III.III, P. 139)

The énoncé is not concealed; it is **residual** after grammar, logic, and illocution. Archaeology **describes** conditions of existence; it does not interpret a hidden voice. Discourse: a population of énoncés under one formation. Circle without first term: formations and énoncés correct each other. **For the app**. `extract` as summary = interpretation. `extract` as monument (structure, citations, source pointer) = description. After parse/embed/classify, the remainder is: does this exist as a statement in *Projet Complexe*? If the index only points at vectors, that remainder is gone. Do not ask “what did the user really mean.” Ask which énoncés exist and what can be done with them.

RARETÉ, EXTÉRIORITÉ, CUMUL (III.IV, P. 155)

Against three themes of the history of ideas:

History of ideas	Archaeology
Plenitude (the unsaid is full)	Rareté — few things are said; gaps are gaps
Interiority (intent, mind)	Extériorité — stay with surfaces and relations
Accumulation as becoming-conscious	Cumul — technical forms of remaining-with-the-said

For the app. Indexing everything is plenitude. Inferring user intent into the store is hermeneutic filling. Context stuffing and unbounded `research` are anti-rarity. *Projet Complexe* is already an *environment* (outside); the failure mode is promising it will coincide with the user’s mind. Git, indexes, exports, changelogs are forms of cumul — unless summarisation *replaces* the monument. ASC: material cumul without a theory of meaning.

A PRIORI HISTORIQUE ET ARCHIVE (III.V, P. 166)

A priori historique: conditions of *reality* of énoncés, changeable — not Kant, not “what the model can generate.” Here: CWT wrappers, no workspace switch from `$HOME`, nested-git rule, three-scope split, changelog practice. **Archive**: the law of what can be said; the system that governs the appearance of énoncés as events. Not the sum of texts. We are **inside**; description is regional. Exhaustive archive-export is a fantasy. **For the app**. `data/ideas/` is not the archive. The vector DB is not the archive. The archive is the system of rules: what may be indexed, executed, published, what counts as a research result, what remains unsaid because no pivot admits it. `index` is a surface of appearance, a rarefaction operator. Policy-plus-unlimited-generator is police on plenitude, not an archive. Success of a shell command ≠ existence of an énoncé in this archive (`git status` in a nested repo can succeed computationally and fail enunciatively). Do not add `archive` as an ASC type.

IV — LA DESCRIPTION ARCHÉOLOGIQUE (P. 175)

AGAINST THE HISTORY OF IDEAS (IV.I, P. 177)

History of ideas: genesis, continuity, totalisation, origin, influence, secret, œuvre. Archaeology: discourse as monument, conditions of existence, dispersion, transformation of rules. Not a more rigorous history of ideas. Another project.

For the app. LLM-assisted knowledge work is the history of ideas by default (summarise intent, find influences, extract the spirit). A second brain as “the story of my thought” is that discipline applied to the self. Projet Complexe can hold tasks and relations without telling that story.

ORIGINAL / RÉGULIER (IV.II, P. 184)

Value regularity and **derivation** (governing énoncés vs derived), not genius. Chronology can invert: a late rule reorganises earlier traces. Similarity is not influence.

For the app. A successful run is an énonciation. Promoting it to a skill claims a repeatable énoncé — say whether it governs or is a case. Embeddings are machines for fake influence. `git log` is material cumul, not enunciative derivation.

CONTRADICTIONS (IV.III, P. 195)

Do not resolve into deeper coherence. Do not motorise as dialectic. Describe levels: exclusive strategies held together; sentence-level only; extra-discursive vs discursive (one disk pushes fusion; the three scopes refuse it).

For the app. The revival rule (PC uses ASC without becoming ASC-specific; PCA uses ASC specifically without becoming a second ASC) is a held contradiction, not a paradox to synthesise in v3. Do not run a “make my notes consistent” agent by default.

COMPARATIVE FACTS (IV.IV, P. 205)

Regional, not a science of all Discourse. **Intra** (inside one practice), **inter** (among practices: ASC / PC / CWT / GitOps), **extra** (machines, mounts, dedi — condition, do not “express”). **Épistémè**: set of *relations* among practices that give rise to knowledge-figures and sciences — not a worldview, not “the age of agents.”

For the app. `relate` needs kinds (derived-from, extracted-from, contradicts, extra-discursive condition). Untyped links restore totality. Extra-discursive nodes stay ASC-addressable things; do not turn the Nextcloud mount into a knowledge object.

CHANGE (IV.V, P. 216)

Transformation of **rules of formation**, on several clocks, several cuts. A model swap is not a *coupure* if pivots, objects, and positions stay. Adding `stop-agent` is a change of modalities even if the model stays. Do not narrate architecture as becoming-what-it-was-trying-to-be.

For the app. Changelog: event vs materiality vs rules-of-formation. `build` produces artifacts; transformation is not a build.

SCIENCE ET SAVOIR (IV.VI, P. 232)

Savoir: what can be spoken of in a practice; positions; coordination of énoncés; uses — including the clinic around a science. **Science** nests in savoir at thresholds: **positivité** → **épistémologisation** (figures of verification) → **scientificité** → **formalisation**. Not a mandatory staircase. Not a ranking of dignity.

For the app. Projet Complexe may earn a positivity. It is not a science. Kill the phrase “put it in the knowledge base.” Replace with: admit this énoncé to this practice’s champ de présence, under this regime, from this position — or do not. Metrics are not scientificité. ASC’s vocabulary is a thin formalisation of computational things; it is not a formalisation of savoir.

V — CONCLUSION (P. 257)

A dialogue. Keep the critic as a position in the associated field:

- Distance from structuralism is not failed linguistics. Discourse is not a language. Do not demand an ontology as the archive.
- The subject is dispersed into positions, not destroyed. Neither “the model has no self so nothing is said” nor “the model is a colleague with inner life.”
- Archaeology describes existence of énoncés. It does not replace truth-programs. Mixing them into one knowledge layer is universal mediation (Hegel as a vector store).
- Method after the fact is the circle without first term — not développement (“we were always going here”).
- Political horizon (not this book’s centre): who may occupy positions, which énoncés are rarefied. `inspect-agent` / `stop-agent` are anti-anonymous. They are not a theory of power.

Three restorations to refuse, which agent tooling repeats constantly: **founding subject**, **original experience** (true intent), **universal mediation**. The three scopes exist to block the third. ASC does not mediate meaning. PC does not mediate processes. PCA mediates only by thin names of operations.

PIVOTS

Pivot	Temptation	Constraint
<code>research</code>	commentary; unbounded concomitance; science-costume	practice with admission rules, budget, stop; subordinate to a task
<code>index</code>	become the archive; index everything	rarefaction; surface of appearance; pointer to monuments
<code>extract</code>	summary as the source	derived énoncé; source remains; original rasters
<code>recognize</code>	detect the thing-in-itself	grid on a surface under an authority
<code>relate</code>	influence / cosine / totality	named kinds; associated field
<code>build</code>	artifact = transformation of rules	material; declare if the regime of monuments changed

Pivot	Temptation	Constraint
run-agent	founding subject; run = law	occupancy of a position; unique énonciation
inspect-agent	inner life / CoT as soul	exteriority: process, capabilities, field, traces
stop-agent	never stop, or stop without a right	emptying a place; rarity in time
publish	the Book as truth	change of materiality and field

RAG, COMMENTARY, “KNOWLEDGE BASE”

Standard RAG (chunk → embed → top-k → stuff window → generate) looks like archaeology and is the history of ideas automated: chunk ≠ énoncé, neighbourhood ≠ formation, corpus ≠ archive, top-k ≠ rarity, window ≠ associated field, generation ≠ occupancy, “what they meant” ≠ description. It can still be a **technique of cumul** if chunks point at monuments, retrieval is admission not soup, the generator occupies a named position, k is declared rarefaction, and nobody claims the index is knowledge, archive, or science. Commentary (restoration of a hidden voice) is the toolchain default. Monument discipline is the alternative: work the configuration, keep the source, declare the filter.

LEXICON (WHAT EACH TERM FORBIDS)

Term	Forbids in this app
<i>énoncé</i>	treating a chunk or chat line as already knowledge
<i>archive</i>	treating the store as the law of what can be said
<i>formation</i>	unifying by tag, folder, or topic cluster
<i>objet</i>	“document” as a natural kind
<i>position</i>	persona, user-model, team soul
<i>rareté</i>	index-everything; infer the unsaid into the store
<i>extériorité</i>	second brain as inner me
<i>cumul</i>	summary that replaces the monument
<i>savoir</i>	calling the app a science
<i>épistémè</i>	“the age of agents” as a worldview
<i>œuvre / auteur</i>	the user’s corpus as one Work

Do not implement these as ASC primitives. If a term forbids nothing, drop it.

WHAT TO IMPLEMENT (LITTLE)

In Projet Complexe or PCA, not as ASC types:

- named occupancies (capabilities, trees, inspect/stop);
- monument discipline for extract/index (source pointers);
- typed **relate** (few kinds);
- explicit rarefaction (what is not indexed, on purpose);
- declared regimes of repetition (md/pdf; log/note);
- changelogs that can say when *rules* changed, not only artifacts.

Refuse: Foucault types in ASC; a prompt “you are an archaeologist”; completeness of the archive; fusion with Morin and Meadows into one framework; the user’s life as an œuvre; the model as a subject.

EDITION

Source scan: [L'archéologie du savoir, 1969, Michel Foucault.pdf](#) (JBIG2, no text layer, no figures). Printed parts: Introduction p. 7; Les régularités discursives p. 29; L'énoncé et l'archive p. 103; La description archéologique p. 175; Conclusion p. 257.